Hamas, the wife badly wounded, and their teenage daughter taken as a hostage to Gaza. During the two weeks he spent in Israel, no official got in touch with him, nobody came with information, nobody tried to reach him, nothing. It was only when he was back in the States that he learned, from one of four female hostages who were released, that his cousin was alive in Gaza.

Thursday, October 26

Israeli armed forces made an overnight incursion into northern Gaza in readiness for the wider ground operation. There were no casualties among the soldiers. Simultaneously, suspected military and civilian leaders of Hamas are being identified, found, and executed.

Still no news about the hostage deal. Could it be a release of all hostages in return for an end to the Gaza operation? Such a proposal would confront Israel with a terrible dilemma: sacrificing the lives of about 200 of its citizens and waging an uncertain campaign against Hamas, or letting Hamas survive and saving the lives of the hostages. Undoubtedly, the hostages are the national priority.

A poll published on October 13 shows a dramatic downslide of Netanyahu to only nineteen mandates, while Gantz has climbed to a stunning forty-one mandates. Lapid would garner fifteen mandates. Shas would lose half its mandates, and Religious Zionism (which merged the Jewish Home and Religious Zionist Parties) together with Jewish Power would garner a mere nine mandates. The poll also gives six mandates to Meretz and another six to Yisrael Beiteinu. In short, a tremendous surge of the center and center-right and an amazing downfall of the hard-right and religious right. This explains of course why Netanyahu declared, after the publication of these results, that he would finally answer questions about what happened on October 7. Too little and too late.